March 25, 1911

(From Fragments from the Fire)

By Chris Llewellyn

(Pg 4-9) It was Spring. It was Saturday.

Payday. For some it was Sabbath.

Soon it will be Easter. It was

approaching April, nearing Passover.

It was close to closing time.

INTRODUCTION

The Triangle Shirtwaist Factory Fire -- the deadliest workplace accident in New York City's history. An event that highlighted the disgusting nature of the "sweatshop" in America –sweatshops where children as young as 13 were paid a mere $15 a week and who were forced to work 12 hours a day, every day.

On March 25th, 1911, the blaze ripped through the congested 8th, 9th and 10th floors of the building as petrified workers -- mostly teen-age immigrant girls who spoke little English -- desperately tried to make their way downstairs. By the time the fire burned itself out, 146 people were dead. Forty-nine workers had burned to death or been suffocated by smoke, 36 were dead in the elevator shaft and 58 died from jumping to the sidewalks.

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This poem takes us back to that fateful day. It was spring, it was Saturday, it was payday and it was close to closing time on March 25, 1911 . . . . by Chris Llewellyn

The heads of trees budding

in Washington Square Park.

The sun a hot flywheel spinning

the earth's axle. The days long

enough for leaving in light.

It was Spring.

America's sweethearts – the ladies --

stroll in shirtwaists of lawn and lace,

Mimic Charles Dana Gibson's Girls.

They pose in finery cut from bolts of

flimsy and stitched by garment girls

on Gibbs, Wilcox, and Singer machines.

It was Saturday.

Up in the Ash Building

in the Triangle Shirtwaist Company

Rosie Glantz is singing "Every Little

Movement Has a Meaning of Its Own." *

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Fixing hair, arranging puffs and trendils,
the other girls in the cloakroom join in:
(Sing) "Let me call you Sweetheart,
I'm in love with you." **

It was Payday.

Attar-of-roses, lily of the valley,
still they smell of machine oil
that soaks the motors and floors.
The barrel in each stairwell
could fill a thousand lamps.

For some it was Sabbath.

Here at Triangle, Sophie Salemi
and Della Costello sew on Singers.
Neighbors from Cherry Street,
they piecework facing each other,
the oil pan hitting their knees.
Tomorrow sisters will nail flowers
on tenement doors.

Soon it will be Easter.

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The machine heads connected by belts
to the flywheel to rotating axle
sing the Tarantella. Faster,
Faster vibrate the needles, humming
faster the fashionable dance.

It was approaching April.

Della and Sophie up on Ninth
piece sleeves, race the needle's pace
no knowing on Eighth, paper patterns
burn from the wire, fall on machines,
Spark moths and pinwheels round the room.
Rockets push up cutting-tables.

It was nearing Passover.

On Eighth, cutters throw pails of water
on the lawn of lame, and Louis,
Holding the canvas hose, hollers:
"No pressure! Nothing coming!"

It was close to closing time.

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Down on Green Street, Old Dominick
Pushes his wheelbarrow, describes
"a big puff" when windows popped,
glittering showers of glass.
It was Spring.

Flaming swords, Pluto piles to Ninth.
Sophie and Della and dozens of others
jump on machine tables; the aisles jammed
with wicker workbaskets and chairs.
It was Saturday.

Mrs. Yaller testified: "Some froze at
machines. Others were packed in the cloakroom
filled with smoke. I heard them yelling
in Yiddish or Italian, crying out
the names of their children."
It was Payday.

Reporter Bill Shepherd is writing:
"I remember the great strike of last year,
these same girls demanding decent

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working conditions."
For some it was Sabbath.

Rosie runs to the stairway. The door,
Locked! The telephone, Dead! Piling red
Ribbons, fire backs girls into windows.
They stand on sills, see the room
a smashed altar lamp, hear the
Screaming novenas of flame.
Soon it will be Easter.

Pleats of purple and gold wave,
incandescent filaments of lace snow
in shrapnel of needles and screws.
The blaze from molten bolts stains
glass, walls and lawns – on Cherry Street
sisters nail flowers on tenement doors.
It was approaching April.

"I could see them falling,"
Said Lena Goldman. "I was sweeping out
front of my café. At first we thought

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it was bolts of cloth – till they opened
with legs! I still see the day
it rained children. Yes.
It was nearly Passover"

Sophie and Della stand on windowsill,
look out on the crazy quilt of town:
We will leave for our
block on Cherry Street,
Leave these skeletons
leaning on machines,
the faces fixed on black
crucifix of cloakroom window.
It was close to closing time.

The Times quotes Mr. Porter: "The Triangle
never had a fire drill – only three factories
in the city have. One man I pleaded
with replied, 'Let em burn. They're
A lot of cattle anyhow.'"
It was Spring.

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Sophie and Della stand on sill:
We will leave, our arms
around each other, our only
sweethearts. Piling red roses
two white hearses pull up
Cherry Street and the Children
of Mary Society march
in banners of Prayers.
It was Saturday.

Captain Henry was the first policeman to arrive:
"I saw dozens of girls hanging from sills.
Others, dresses on fire, leapt from the ledges."
It was Payday.

Sophie and Della look on crazy quilt of town:
Fifty of our schoolmates
sing in procession:
O Trinity of Blessed Light
Our Lady of Perpetual Help
Ave Maria, Ave Maria
Now and at the Hour

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of the Tarantella.

For some it was Sabbath.

Ordering the nets and ladders, Battalion
Chief Worth explains, “I didn’t know
they would come down three and even four
together. Why these little ones went
through life-nets, pavement and all.”

Soon it will be Easter.

Sophie and Della stand on windowsill:
Look, the flywheel sun sinks
in the west. In the Winter
Garden, Mr. Jolson springs
and bows in blackface.

It was approaching April.

At the Metropolitan Opera
George M. Cohan struts “The Rose
of Tralee” to the rich trailing
in diamond-sackcloth, rending
green ashes of dollar bills.

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It was nearing Passover. ‘

Sophie and Della stand on sill,
look down crazy quilt of town:
Intertwined comets we will stream
the nightmares of Triangle Bosses
Joseph Asch
Max Blanck
Isaac Harris.

It was close to closing time.

Our Bosses of the Locked
Doors of Sweetheart Contracts
who in puffs and tendrils
of silent telephones,
Disconnected hoses, barred
shutters, fire escapes
dangling in perpetual no
help on earth in heaven.

It was Spring.

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The Lord is my shepherd

green pastures still

waters anointest heads

With oil overflowing

prepares a table – now

our arms around each other

we thread the needles

where no rich man can go spinning

the earth's axle we are

leaving in light.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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* ***The song "Every Little Movement has a Meaning of its Own" can be heard at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mnFrCn9_FSc***

You may consider adding a couple of "sung" lines from the chorus to the poem at this point.

** ***The song "Let Me Call You Sweetheart" can be heard at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nnFLOPHJWlo***

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